

SEEDBEARER FAMILY

The Conversation You Keep Avoiding

*A simple way to start talking with your teen about who they really are —
without a script, a lecture, or another awkward silence.*

by James — Seedbearer Family Coaching

The conversation nobody has

You've thought about it. Probably more than once. There's a conversation you keep meaning to have with your teenager — about who they really are, about how they're actually doing underneath the shrug and the one-word answers, about whether they know how much you see in them.

And then dinner happens. Or homework. Or the moment passes because it never felt like the right time, and honestly, you weren't sure what you'd even say.

This isn't a failure of love. It's a failure of a starting line. Most parents don't avoid this conversation because they don't care — they avoid it because nobody ever handed them an opening that didn't feel forced, clinical, or like a performance review.

You don't need the perfect words. You need permission — for both of you — to not get it right the first time.

That's what this is. Not a script to memorize. A short, field-tested way in — used at my own table, with my own kids, before it was ever written down.

Why this conversation stalls out

If you've tried before and it didn't go anywhere, it probably wasn't because your teen doesn't want to be known. It's because of how most of these conversations start.

What usually happens	What it communicates
It opens with a concern or a correction	This is about a problem, not about you
It's framed as a talk they have to sit through	You are the audience, not a participant
There's an expected right answer	It's safer to say nothing
It has to get resolved in one sitting	If this gets uncomfortable, I've failed

None of that is a parenting failure. It's just an approach that was never built for this particular conversation. The one below was.

Four moves, not a script

This isn't something you read aloud. It's four things to get right, in order, in your own words. I've used this exact sequence — including the parts that feel exposing to say out loud — at my own kitchen table.

1. Own your part first

Before you ask anything of your teen, name something true about yourself as a parent. Not a confession session — one honest sentence.

"I know as parents we've made mistakes, and you probably haven't always felt accepted and understood."

This does something specific: it lowers your teen's guard before you've asked them to lower it themselves. You go first. That's the whole move.

2. Say the thing the whole conversation is for

Somewhere near the start, say — out loud, plainly — that they are valuable, and what they bring to your family and the world matters. Not implied. Said.

"You are valuable, and what you bring to our family and to the world around you is valuable. This is going to be the start of a really important conversation."

3. Ask — don't tell

Then hand it over. One question, genuinely open, with a second half that matters as much as the first:

"What feels true about how I see you right now? Was there anything that didn't feel true?"

The second half tells your teen that you're not the final authority on who they are — they are. That's what makes it safe to answer honestly instead of performing the answer they think you want.

4. Give permission before you need it

Say this part out loud, to the whole room, before anyone has to ask for it:

"You don't have to share tonight. It's yours. You get to disagree, take time, or feel awkward about this — most families never have this conversation at all, so we're all learning together."

This one line does more work than anything else here. It removes the pressure that kills the conversation before it starts — the fear that there's a wrong answer, or a deadline on being ready.

If it gets hard

It might. Your teen might go quiet, push back, or say “this isn't me.” That's not a sign it's going wrong — for most families, this is the first time this conversation has ever been attempted. Here's what to say:

“This is more of a reference than a rulebook. Some people find they're a mix of a few things. This isn't a diagnosis — it's meant to help us talk. You get to disagree, need time, or feel awkward. Most families never have this conversation, so we're all learning together.”

If someone leaves the table after that — let them. Come back in a week, one-to-one, without an audience. The goal was never to finish tonight.

Close it like this

End the same way every time, regardless of how far you got:

“I think our family is beginning to find out — together.”

You don't have to build this alone

This conversation is a doorway, not the whole house. If it opened something up — for you or for them — the next step is a free, ten-minute Seed Assessment that helps you and your family put language to who each of you actually are, and how you fit together.

“Who do you think you are?” That question is where every conversation in this family starts. The Seed Assessment is where you begin to answer it.

Take the free Seed Assessment

seedbearerfamily.com/assessment

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